

Supporting you around the world

Beyond Travel

Issue
One

Through his lens

At just 27 years old,
Houston has
travelled to over
thirty countries,
and captured
every one



Around the world

87 countries, but Harry's story is about much more

Time for a break?

Discover how a holiday can boost the whole family

Where to next

Which country has vibrant cities and over 300 lakes?



**"The trip was only
7 days, but the
friendships I made
will last a lifetime"**

Go Beyond Holidays
guest, Greece 2025

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Welcome

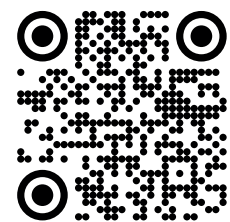
Welcome to the very first edition of Beyond Travel.

This magazine has been created with a simple purpose: to make travel more accessible, inclusive and most of all inspiring for adults with autism and learning disabilities. It has grown from the heart of Go Beyond Holidays from the experiences, friendships, and the unforgettable moments we see on every trip.

Over the years, we've watched so many people discover new places, build confidence and create memories that last far beyond the holiday itself. We wanted to find a way to share that. Inside these pages, you'll find helpful guidance, tips, destination inspiration and real experiences from supported holidays and weekend breaks. Whether you're new to travelling or an experienced adventurer, we hope this magazine becomes a source of ideas, inspiration and excitement for what's possible. This first edition is all about sensory accessibility and is just the beginning. Thank you for being part of this journey with us.



**Ian Callen
& Florence Voller**
Co-Editors at
Beyond Travel



Enjoyed the issue? Why not subscribe to get Issue two delivered to your inbox! Scan the QR code or click the pic of the cover below



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(Images Houston Vandergriff, Harry Scott-Bowden, Ian Callen, Florence Voller)

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Beyond the comfort zone

My name is Harry and I was diagnosed with Asperger's Syndrome at nine years old. So far, I have travelled to 87 countries. That number often surprises people.



Travel is usually associated with spontaneity, unpredictability and effortless social interaction, three things that do not always come naturally to people with autism, myself included. Yet travel has become one of the defining parts of my life.

I did not begin travelling because I was fearless. I began because I was curious. I wanted to understand how the world works, how different places feel and how people live beyond the patterns I grew up with. What I discovered was unexpected. Travel offered structure through planning, comfort through routines I could control and purpose through deep interests in geography, transport systems, history and conservation.

Where It Began

That curiosity became reality when I left school and spent ten weeks doing voluntary work in Tanzania. It was my first time being so far from home, fully

immersed in an unfamiliar environment. Everything felt different, the sounds, the pace of life, the expectations. It pushed me far beyond my comfort zone.

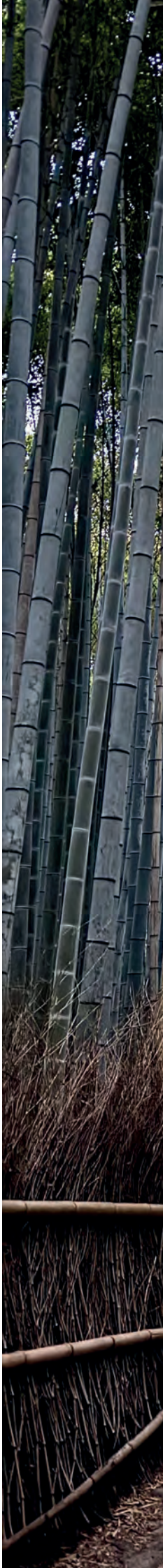
But it also showed me that I was more capable than I had believed. I gained independence and perspective and I realised something important: travel did not have to mean chaos. With the right preparation, it could be manageable and even grounding.

Why Travel Works for Me

It gives me a kind of clarity that everyday life often does not. At home, unspoken social rules and expectations can feel draining. In unfamiliar places, those expectations reset. I am not confined by the same roles or assumptions. I can observe, learn and move at my own pace.

Although travel appears unpredictable from the outside, it allows me to build strong structure into every trip. I research extensively, create detailed itineraries, plan transport, accommodation and >

(Words & images Harry Scott-Bowden)





Arashiyama
Bamboo
Forest, Japan



**“Travel
gives me a
clarity that
everyday
life often
does not”**



Cappadocia,
Turkey



Wild tiger, Ranthambore National Park



downtime. That preparation makes me feel calmer and more regulated than daily life.

Exploring also allows me to engage deeply with my interests. The objectives are clear: reach this place, learn its history, experience its landscape. The goals are tangible and the progress is visible. It can still be overwhelming though. Airports are noisy. Cities are crowded. Plans change. But the challenges are defined and that makes them easier to process. Travel is not an escape from my autism. It is something that works with it.

People often focus on the number: 87 countries. It sounds impressive, but the number itself is not what matters. It is the setbacks, the problem solving and the small wins that have shaped me. Each trip teaches me more about how I manage sensory overload, communicate under pressure and adapt when things go wrong. Counting countries is easy, learning from them is what truly counts.

The Importance of Organised Tours

I usually travel with organised tours and they are essential to how I explore the world. They provide predictability in environments that might otherwise feel

chaotic. Knowing the itinerary in advance and having someone else coordinate logistics significantly reduces stress. That predictability helps me conserve energy and manage sensory overload.

Tours also provide a safety net. If something goes wrong, there is a guide or group to turn to. I do not have to constantly make decisions about routes or timing. That mental space allows me to focus on learning and experiencing. For me, organised travel is not restrictive. It is enabling, it turns something potentially overwhelming into something sustainable.

Building Independence

Recently, I took a major step. I planned and completed a two and a half week trip to Japan and South Korea independently.

I would not have had the confidence to do that without years of travelling on organised tours first. They taught me how airports function, how to navigate train systems and how to pace myself. Within that framework, I learned the mechanics of travel.

With that foundation, I created my own structure by mapping routes, booking accommodation, building rest time into my schedule and preparing contingency ➤



plans. It was challenging at times, but completing the trip showed me that I can trust my

preparation. My favourite city in Japan was Kyoto. Its history and traditions made every street feel purposeful, especially the hike through Fushimi Inari Shrine, where thousands of torii gates climb the hillside. The highlight was an evening walk through Gion, where I learned about the discipline and artistry of geisha. It deepened my respect for the dedication required to preserve such traditions.

When Structure Matters Most

Not everything goes smoothly though. On another trip, arriving in Delhi was overwhelming. When I reached my hotel, I was told it was unavailable and that I would be moved elsewhere. For many people, that is an inconvenience. For me, sudden change creates uncertainty and uncertainty destabilises me. Instead of reacting, I asked for specifics: the name of the new hotel, the distance and the transport plan. Each answer restored a piece of structure.

The next day, I was due to travel by train to Ranthambore National Park for a safari. I was taken to the wrong platform of the train station. I stood alone on a very crowded platform, unsure whether I was in the right place. The problem was not the crowd, it was the uncertainty and I

could feel a meltdown approaching.

So I narrowed the problem. I checked the train number. I confirmed the departure time. I reminded myself that someone was expecting me at the other end. I did not need to solve the entire journey. I only needed clarity about the next step. Eventually, a representative found me and guided me to the correct carriage. Once certainty was restored, I could breathe again.

The following day, all of that stress felt worthwhile. During the safaris in Ranthambore National Park, I had two sightings of wild tigers. Watching them move silently through their natural habitat was surreal, calm and powerful.

At that moment, the uncertainty of the previous day no longer defined the experience. The reward was not just seeing the tigers. It was proving to myself that I could endure the difficult parts to reach something extraordinary.

What Travel has Taught Me

As a person with autism, travel it's not about being fearless it's about preparation, structure, self-awareness and persistence. It means understanding how your mind works and building systems that allow you to thrive. Eighty seven countries later, I am still curious and still learning.

Eighty seven countries later, I am still curious and still learning. **BT**

Harry at
Jokulsarlon
lagoon,
Iceland 2022



Harry's
travels in numbers

87
countries
visited &
counting

200
number of
flights taken

Chiriguano Bay,
Antarctica



**"The best
holiday I've
ever been on,
I've already
booked the
next one!"**

**Go Beyond Holidays
guest, Azores 2025**



The A-Z of supported travel

Providing supported travel is about more than just getting from A to B. It's about ensuring everyone can explore the world safely and joyfully.

Adventure Additional needs are not a barrier to visiting a new destination or experiencing a bucket-list adventure.

Buddy A travel buddy can provide social and physical support to navigate unfamiliar environments with confidence.

Communication Clear, accessible communication is key to a smooth holiday.

Downtime Travelling can be tiring and overstimulating. Scheduled downtime is essential for sensory regulation.

Empower The goal is to empower individuals to gain independence and develop invaluable life skills.

Fun With all of the logistical and caregiving requirements taken care of, guests can focus entirely on having fun!

Guidance Staff provide expert guidance to navigate around new countries and unfamiliar surroundings.

Holistic A holistic approach to care ensures that emotional and physical needs are considered and met at all times for every guest.

Inclusive Supported trips champion inclusive tourism by visiting attractions, and activities that are accessible for everyone involved.

Journey Support workers focus on making the journey itself as comfortable as possible

Kindness Patient, non-judgmental kindness from staff builds the trust needed for guests to feel at ease.

Logistics Effectively managing logistics - from flight bookings to medical supplies - is essential for a trip to be successful.

Memories Supported travel provides experiences to make happy memories that last a lifetime

Newcomer Extra reassurances are helpful to newcomers who may be travelling alone for the first time.

One-to-one High needs may be met through one-to-one support being provided.

Planning Planning and pre-departure risk assessments are vital to prevent anything that could potentially derail a trip.

Quality A high quality of care is provided so that guests receive the same standard of support while on holiday as they do at home.

Respect Every trip is centred around respect for every traveller's dignity, autonomy and personal boundaries.

Support Professional support workers help guests step outside of their comfort zones.

Tailored No two disabilities are the same so every aspect of a supported holiday is tailored to the individual.

Unique Supported travel champions the unique perspectives and abilities of every traveller.

Visibility Increasing the visibility of people with additional needs in tourist spaces helps create a more educated community around the world.

Wellbeing Ensuring that everyone's physical and mental health is being looked after is a constant priority.

Xenophile Encouraging a xenophile attitude - a love of foreign cultures - helps to promote an appreciation of travel and feeling a part of the wider world.

Yummy Meeting dietary needs helps travellers to sample the yummy flavours and foods of the world.

Zen Support staff create zen, low-anxiety environments in which guests can truly relax.



Gem of the Mediterranean

As you fly into Malta, one colour stands out amongst the blue of the clear sky and that's gold. As the aeroplane circles the island, the golden yellow buildings of Valletta and the Three Cities inch closer.



Below you can see a golden history of Malta in its warm

architecture. These sunny islands have not just been shaped by waves from the sea, but by waves of invaders over the millennia.

Phoenicians, Romans, Arabs, Normans, French and the British, all adding their stories and colour to the islands, in the shape of magnificent churches, palaces and impressive bastions.

The sunshine yellow and gold of the Maltese buildings come from globigerina limestone which can be naturally sourced on the islands. The colour of the stone changes over time, giving the island's architecture a weathered and lived in appearance.

These hues are complemented by the vibrant tones used in windows and doors, from deep red and brown to olive green and cobalt blue.

Diverse Culture

What about the many shades of neurodiversity? The varied experiences within the learning disability community? How does Malta welcome this diverse and often overlooked group of travellers? We set out to find the answers.

We spoke to Jimmy Rule, who travelled to Malta in March 2025 with a group of fellow travellers, to hear about the journey in his own words. "I had a good holiday in Malta, the people were welcoming and kind, and it wasn't crowded or noisy at all. I liked the tours and they were paced just right for me. I especially liked the views, the boat trip and the food tour. I saw old churches, fountains and a lighthouse."

Jimmy stayed at the Qawra Palace and Spa. "The Hotel and

its facilities were good, I enjoyed the food with its different themed meals every night," he says. "The spa was nice and I enjoyed swimming and had fun in the sauna. There was also crazy golf at the hotel which I enjoyed. In the evenings there was entertainment like karaoke and the dancing." We also had a chat with Jimmy's mother, Miranda. She helps Jimmy to book his holidays and she said: "Malta is the best Holiday Jimmy has ever had, it was the diversity of daytime activities that kept Jimmy stimulated and occupied. The events every evening at the hotel meant he wasn't bored, but at a pace that didn't stress him out either."

After speaking with Jimmy we looked at the structures around Malta's tourism to see what provisions are in place for neurodiverse people. ➤

“Malta’s iconic attractions have been thoughtfully adapted”





Malta International Airport

The airport in Malta provides comprehensive support for travellers of all abilities. For neurodiverse travellers, the airport offers a dedicated Autism-Friendly Programme designed to make the journey through the terminal calm and manageable.

It has easy to understand maps of the whole airport, with travel tips, point-to-point transfer distances in metres. Should you book their support service at the airport, then there is also a short video that shows you how the process works when you arrive at the airport and when you depart on your final day.

Cultural Sites Made Accessible

Malta's iconic attractions have been thoughtfully adapted for visitors of all abilities, with sensory friendly initiatives as common practice. Sites include; St John's Co-Cathedral, Valletta,

Fort St Elmo, National Museum of Archaeology and Ġgantija Temples, Gozo.

Public Transport

Getting around Malta on the buses has been made easy on the Malta Public Transport website, which is easy to use with clear tabs for timetables, routes and prices. Tolene Van Der Merwe at Visit Malta says: "We are continuously working to improve accessibility across the islands, and partnerships with operators such as Go Beyond Holidays play a vital role in showcasing Malta as a welcoming, supportive and enriching destination for all travellers."

Go Beyond are planning a trip to Malta in October 2026. If you are interested in discovering the colours of Malta for yourself, and you are dreaming of a mediterranean getaway, then visit the Go Beyond Holidays website. **BT**

Malta - Gem of the Mediterranean

Date

4th – 11th October 2026

Nights 7

Accommodation

QAWRA Palace Resort and Spa hotel

Food

All food will be catered for by the hotel

Price

£3280 (All Inclusive)



(Images Ian Callen Unsplash Reuben Farrugia, Nick Fewings)

Chaos in an Airport



A Poem by
Amelia Weldon

Feeling claustrophobic
in a sea of faces,
shoulder to shoulder in
departure spaces,

The air feels thick,
it's hard to breathe,
Mind in panic
No sign of ease,
Clock ticking,
gate unknown,
A fear of dealing
with it alone.

Racing through,
the "hectic zone",
Rolling screens we
forever condone,

Constant chatter,
Family brawls,
Babies crying,
Boarding calls,

All the what ifs, never far away,
What if the skies refuse today?
Connections missed,
Cancellations in red,
Worst-case scenarios
within your head.

Stress awakens
beneath your skin,
Panic rises,
deep within.
Frustration builds
at every delay,
System failures
lead us astray.

With early starts at
darkest hour,
Sleep cut short, thoughts
start to sour
The fragile trust begins to break,
All these outcomes, impossible
to take,

Limited options
for those with allergies,
Anxiety sets in,
with each new reality.

Yet

There are ways to
enjoy the flight,
Fade fear and bring
hope to light,
Allow more time than
you will need,
Moving with patience,
not with speed.

A shorter line
with luck you will find,
Then let the calm
envelope your mind,
Always travel
with someone you trust,
Even in silence,
if you must,

Ask for help - let others care,
Kindness lingers within the air.

Wear the sunflower lanyard
if you require,
For breathing room
is all you desire,
Staff may meet you
with gentle eyes,
Guiding you through the
chaos and cries.

Breathe in deep,
then let out slow,
Feel your racing heartbeat go,
Once you're through
security's gate,
Find a quiet corner,
sit and wait.

Bring books, puzzles, songs,
Familiar objects to help
you along,
In hand luggage, close to you,
Small comforts, you can
easily do.

Make sure to charge
your phone before,
Pack both wise and light
Keep your passport safe,
easing the mind,
Emergency snacks
tucked away,
Wear comfy clothes
for travel day.

When at last, you
take your seat,
Engines humming
low and deep,
Now breathe in fully,
slow and long,
Now let it go, you're
being strong.

Above the ground,
beyond the skies,
The noise around
will fade to sighs,
Now it's time
to release,
You made it here,
Now enjoy the peace.

Making space in the crowd

End of
the Road
Festival



Festival season is upon us but they can be as daunting as they are exciting. Florence Voller takes a look at the best events supporting festival-goers with additional needs



Come rain or shine, the UK does festivals well. But for some individuals with sensory needs, the idea of seeing their top bands can feel just as daunting as it is exciting.

So what are large-scale organisers doing to truly support and welcome neurodivergent festival-goers? While physical accessibility is becoming more visible, sensory accessibility is often less so.

Sensory Accessibility

Some festivals, including End of the Road which sits on the Wiltshire/Dorset border and Green Man in the Brecon Beacons in South Wales, are leading the way. Their websites offer clear information, often including easy-read formats.

For those who benefit from simplified language and visual support, this can make a significant difference before the event even begins. The introduction of sensory calm tents has also been a positive step, offering a refuge from the intensity of the main arena. Accessibility is measured by how it feels on the ground, navigating crowds, managing sensory

input and enjoying the music in a way that feels safe and supported.

I spoke with Ben, a regular Download attendee and Go Beyond Holiday guest who has autism. What stood out was how positively both he and his mother, Tracey, described the experience. They called Download the most inclusive festival Ben has attended. 'I go to Download for the music, to see great bands and meet people.' Due to additional medical needs, he chose to stay in a nearby hotel, using accessible parking close to the arena; small adjustments that made each day far smoother. The Essential Companion scheme, offering a complimentary ticket for a carer, is another great step towards better accessibility.

The main challenge Ben identified was the merchandise queue. Long waits and crowded spaces can be particularly difficult and he suggested improved access for those who require it, to purchase merchandise without extended queuing.

Shaping the Future

And that brings us to another question: are people with lived experience actively

(Words Florence Voller Images Ben, End of the Road Festival)



shaping accessibility planning? Luke, Communications Coordinator for Gig Buddies, part of the Stay Up Late charity, highlighted the importance of visibility. The organisation supports people with autism and learning disabilities to attend events, not just to enable access but to ensure representation within mainstream spaces. They advocate when challenges arise, feeding back to improve future experiences.

Luke also shared the perspective of Jason, a regular attendee who has been to Glastonbury twice. He believes accessibility could be better embedded into site design, from clearer routes through busy areas to closer positioning of stages, food stalls and toilets. Improved public information and greater affordability for those on disability benefits would also make a difference.

Leading the Way

End of the Road organisers said their approach reflects a growing awareness of sensory needs, with clearly signposted quieter areas and dedicated welfare teams across the site. Practical measures

Ben rocking out at Download Festival. End of the Road Festival

include managing sound levels, selling ear plugs and restricting fireworks. Visual schedules, sensory maps and advanced information help attendees plan ahead. Managed crowd flow and quieter arrival times further support those who may require it. Importantly, accessibility is not treated as a one-time solution.

Ongoing staff training around autism and hidden disabilities, alongside post-event feedback, continues to shape improvements year on year.

Moving Forward

Taken together, these perspectives show that accessibility at festivals is improving, alongside growing awareness of sensory needs. Clearer information and better on-the-ground support are making events easier to navigate and more enjoyable for many festival goers.

However, continued progress depends on organisers embedding accessibility from the outset. With well-trained staff, utilising feedback and thoughtful design, festivals can continue to move towards genuine inclusion for future events to come. **BT**

Everybody needs a break

Specialised holiday services provide assistance so guests can access holidays just like everybody else — but it's not just the guests that benefit them.



For caregivers, the holidays can be a valuable time to catch up on admin, go on holiday themselves, or simply enjoy a welcome break from the usual routine - safe in the knowledge that the person they care for is having all of their needs met. According to figures from Carers UK, there are currently 5.8 million unpaid carers in the UK, with Census data suggesting that 1.7 million of those are providing 50 or more hours of unpaid care every week. Having time away from their role as a carer is incredibly important, and research shows how regular, reliable access to a variety of breaks is essential for carers' mental health and for their wellbeing.

Family Voices

The chair of Carers UK Nick, 64, who cares for his sister, Jackie, 61, (both pictured, right) explains: "I know from my role that respite is critical for most carers, given how demanding the care role can be. A break helps anyone to recharge and come back with a more positive outlook, making it easier to cope with life's challenges."

For Paul, 58, and Michael, 57 — who look after Paul's brother, Matt, 54 - a supported holiday

enabled them to have a week to focus on themselves. "The break did us all good. Spending time apart is healthy for everyone and enables Matt to continue to develop his independence, communication and day-to-day living skills. For us, it supports us by helping us to recharge our batteries."

Kathy, 70, and George, 74, who take care of their daughter Hana, in her 30s, say, "It allows Hana to be independent from us, and engage in activities that are not available near our home." Hana looks forward to this time away. "Supported holidays mean I can do things with other people, not only with my Mum and Dad! I always get very excited," she says.

Peace of Mind

Knowing loved ones are being cared for and supported properly while they're away means that caregivers can fully relax and switch off. "Going on

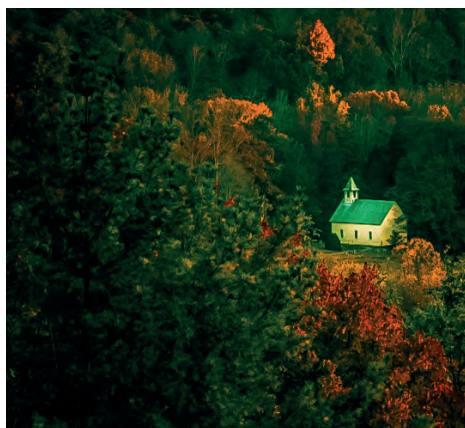
these holidays showed us that stimulation increases Jackie's confidence, both physically and socially," says Nick. "I didn't think I would be able to go on a supported holiday because of my mobility and speech difficulties," Jackie says. "But I loved it!"

Having Adventures

Phil and Rosalind, whose son, Rob, 40, enjoys travelling, explain: "Previously he had been away on his own, but had found it unrewarding and lonely. Supported travel offers more active trips to interesting places. He's the first in our family to see the Northern Lights! These trips really improve his mood and outlook."

With caregivers enjoying a well-deserved break and guests being supported to develop life skills and explore the world, these holidays are invaluable for everyone. The only problem is deciding where to book next.





Through his lens

At just 27 years old, Houston Vandergriff has travelled to over thirty countries, all fifty US states and six Canadian provinces, capturing the world as he sees it; vivid, honest, and full of feeling.



Houston is a travel photographer who uses his camera not just to document places, but to connect with them.

We had the pleasure of speaking with Houston and his mother, Katie, about his creative journey, his love of travel and what photography truly means to him.

How did Houston get into travel photography?

Katie He has had a camera in his hand since he was a little boy. Because speech has always been a challenge, photography became a natural way for him to communicate. He would photograph everyday life, using those images to share his experiences. It was his way of saying, this is my world.

Over time, what began as a tool for communication grew into something more. We recognised his eye for detail and he developed a deep love for capturing moments.

As Houston grew older, he completed photography training and built a portfolio. Travel has expanded that journey even further.

What are you drawn to most?

Houston Beauty, I notice details that many people might miss.

K Houston is especially drawn to colour and light, with sunrises and sunsets among his favourite subjects to capture.

What's your favourite place?

K Choosing one is difficult. For

Houston, a place is defined less by how it looks and more by how it feels and who he meets.

H I keep a photo of the Eiffel Tower on my phone case, it reminds me of a place that stayed with me.

What does travel mean to you?

H Travel means freedom to me, the chance to explore.

K It also represents connection and growth. Travel allows Houston to experience new cultures, build relationships and share his story in a way that encourages inclusion, independence and purpose.

What makes you want to capture a moment?

K For Houston, it's instinctive. When the light feels right or a moment feels meaningful, he knows immediately, sometimes even gasping before picking up his camera.

Where to next?

H I love going somewhere new, it's experiences that excites me.

K He's drawn to places with culture, natural beauty and opportunities to connect. Having visited five continents, he has two left: Australia and Antarctica.

Do you hope to inspire others with Down syndrome?

K Absolutely. We hope Houston's journey expands what people believe is possible. His work challenges stereotypes and highlights the importance of representation. If his

photography encourages even one person to try something new, it has done its job.

What would you say to someone nervous about travelling or being creative?

H Go for it and be confident.

K Take one step at a time. Confidence grows through action, and small steps can lead to big opportunities.

What do you hope people feel when they see your work?

H Joy!

K His photographs invite people to feel the moment as he experienced it. More than anything, they encourage people to slow down and notice the world around them.

Has photography changed how you communicate?

H I find it difficult to find the words sometimes but photographs are my words instead.

K Photography has been transformative. It allows Houston to communicate beyond words and connect with people around the world.

And finally, what should the world understand?

K Houston's story is a reminder that disability does not define limitation. People with Down syndrome have creativity, talent and perspective. Differences are not barriers, they are strengths and by embracing them the world becomes more inclusive. **BT**

You've given Jimmy the possibility of travelling independently (but supported) and having experiences that he couldn't possibly have had otherwise.

Guests' parents, Estonia 2026



The symbol of sunflowers



When you are out and about you may have seen people wearing a green ribbon around their neck. This green lanyard also has striking golden, yellow sunflowers, patterned over the green background.

Being Seen

These Sunflower Lanyards are worn by people who work in public places or who use public services but what purpose do they serve?

We spoke to Annette Cmela, the Global Chief Brand Officer at Hidden Disabilities Sunflower, the company responsible for the lanyard to understand its purpose and creation.

Cmela explained: "The Sunflower Lanyard is a voluntary way for someone with a non-visible disability, condition, or chronic illness to indicate they may need additional support, understanding, or time. It does not explain the disability, and it does not automatically entitle someone to a specific service. Importantly, it does not require the individual to disclose personal medical information. It provides a shared signal that some consideration may be needed."

Sowing the Seed

The Sunflower Lanyard has been very successful: it is now recognised in more than 90 countries, including 327 airports



and 30 airlines. The lanyard was launched in 2016 at Gatwick airport with a straightforward idea, Cmela says: "To create a symbol that staff could recognise, so passengers did not have to keep explaining themselves."

Airports were just the start, they are now recognised in many public services. However, the further the Sunflower Lanyard reaches, the challenge of uneven awareness becomes more prominent. Cmela explains: "It is not just about making lanyards available. It involves staff training, internal alignment and a clear commitment to recognising non-visible disabilities. The focus remains on maintaining awareness and ensuring the symbol continues to mean the same thing across all sectors."



For more info visit the Hidden Disabilities Sunflower website

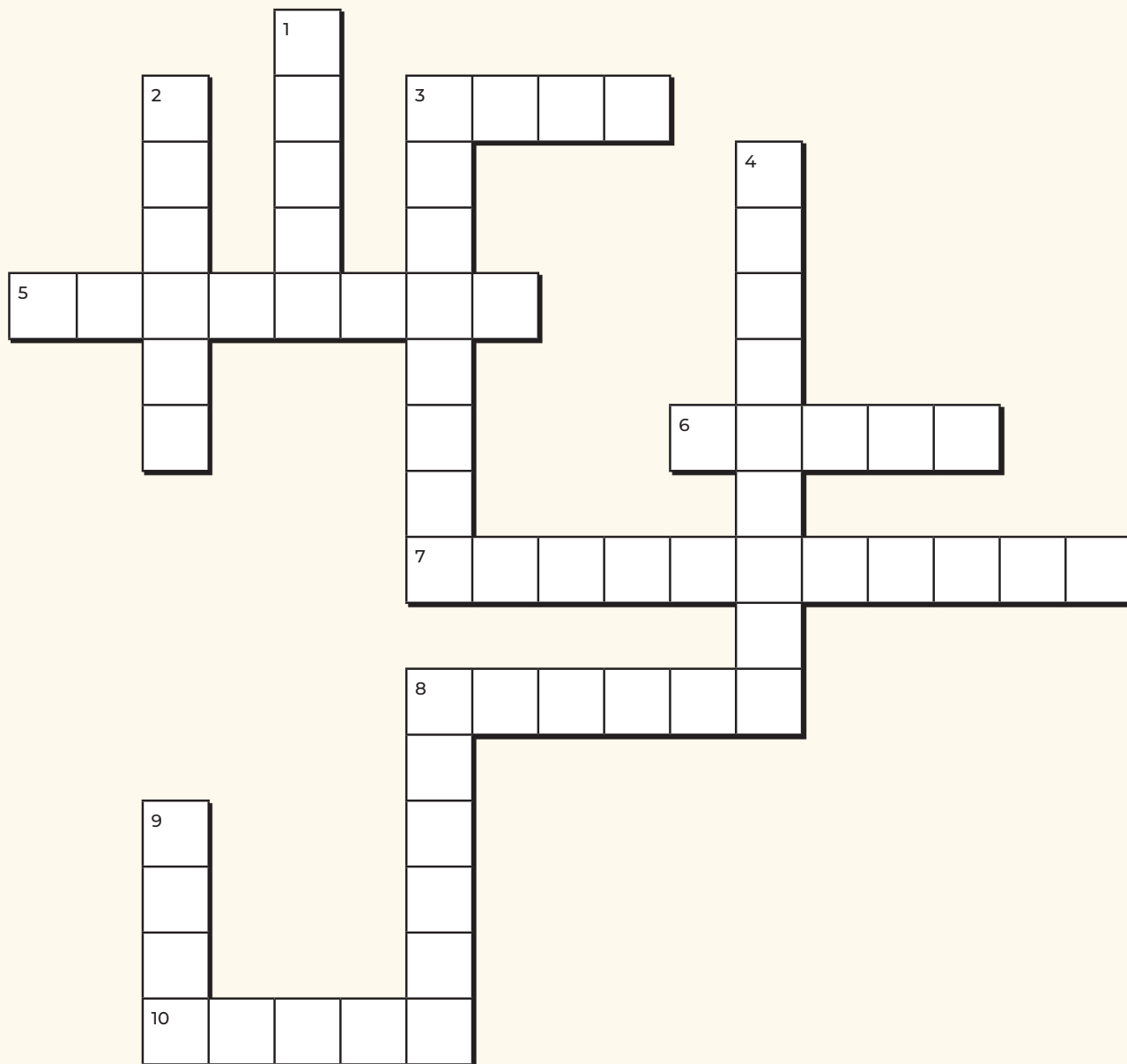
Amelia's view from her lived experience



As a person diagnosed with autistic traits, I have found that people respond differently to being easily identified when using a Sunflower Lanyard. Sometimes I think of it as a lifeline and others I feel misunderstood. When I ask for help understanding someone, people sometimes respond as if I know nothing, when I just need time to process it or hear it explained differently. I also struggle with the idea of being identified as different everywhere I go. However I've been on a group holiday where some guests wore them and we benefited from the lanyard because security was faster and less stressful as a result. I appreciated those that had the confidence to wear them. The Sunflower Lanyard is a simple tool to help others recognise differences without the need for explanation but it's important to stay open-minded. For those who choose to where them they are a useful dignified, non-verbal way of explaining that other people need to be patient.

Amelia Weldon

Puzzlemania



Crossword Vive la France!

Across

- 3** A famous soft French cheese
- 5** French city after which a red wine is named
- 6** How you say thank you in French
- 7** Paris's most famous tall landmark
- 8** How you say four in French
- 10** The river that flows through Paris

Down

- 1** One of the three colours on the French flag
- 2** The current president of France
- 3** The most famous French bread
- 4** France's second largest city
- 8** Another name for a savoury French tart made with eggs
- 9** One of France's mountain ranges, popular for skiing

Quiz time

Anagrams

HABEC

Relax here and watch the sea

NOLABCARE

European city

CUAISTES

Something you might take on holiday

APRONEALE

Travelling at altitude

What am I?

You might need me to come with you on holiday. I'm small and light and I can fit in your bag. I hate getting lost so please keep me safe. Sometimes people have to show me to someone when they travel otherwise they can't go on holiday. I always keep a photo of you!

Match the flags



France



Netherlands



Russia



Luxembourg

Guess the city!



(Image Unsplash Samuel-Pegan-Asante)

Match the national dishes to their countries



Switzerland



Mexico



Greece



Austria



Canada



Morocco



Philippines

Wordsearch



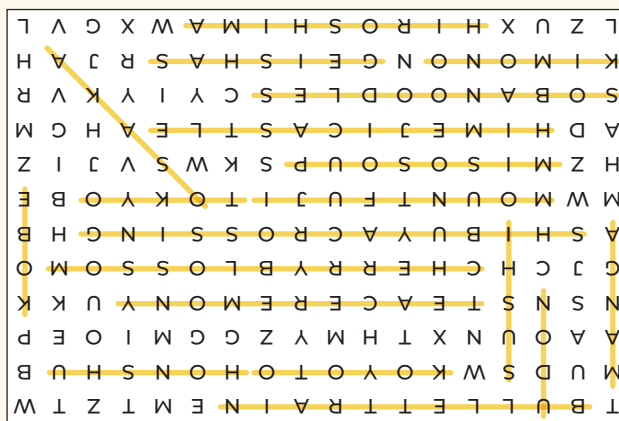
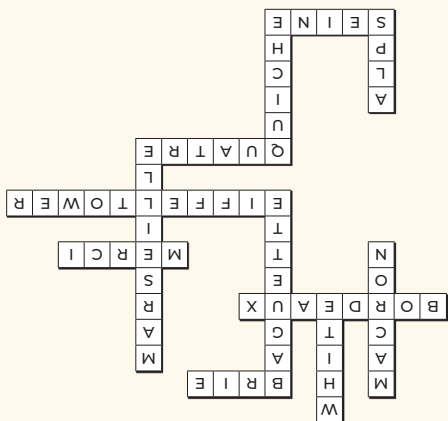
Find the following words in the puzzle. Words are hidden → ↓ and ↘

BULLET TRAIN
CHERRY BLOSSOM
GEISHAS
HIMEJI CASTLE
HIROSHIMA
HONSHU
KIMONO

KOBE
KOYOTO
MANGA
MISO SOUP
MOUNT FUJI
OSAKA
SHIBUYA CROSSING

SOBA NOODLES
SUSHI
TEA CEREmony
TOKYO
UPON

Answers



Anagrams Beach, Barcelona, Sultcase,
Aeroplane **What am I?** A passport **Flags**
Luxembourg, Russia, France, Netherlands
Guess the city London **National dishes**
Chicken adobo - Philippines, tagine
Mintaroc, Poutine - Canada, Tacos - Mexico,
Fondue - Switzerland, Moussaka - Greece,
Weiner Schnitzel - Austria

Expect the unexpected

Travel plans are wonderfully exciting but as anyone who goes away a lot knows, the most memorable moments can often be the ones you never saw coming...



Ian Callen

During a recent trip to Spain we relied heavily on public transport. One journey

involved a 15-minute Metro ride from central Madrid to the Bernabéu Stadium, the home of Real Madrid. As the metro arrived, we could see the carriages were already full with people, packed in like sardines! Not wanting to be late for our tour, we encouraged everyone onto the busy train. The carriage resembled a mass game of Twister. We stood in a hot, crowded, noisy carriage. I was astonished that not one of our guests complained. Perhaps it is a well-worn stereotype; an unhelpful label that says "people with autism don't like confined places". These kinds of labels can be limiting. They can shape my own expectations too, even after more than 15 years working in supported travel.



Florence Voller

Group holidays are usually exactly that - groups. So when one trip was suddenly reduced to just two guests after

a wave of flu cancellations, I was worried. A group holiday for two?! As it turns out, it quickly became one of the most memorable trips we did. With just four of us including staff, we decided to make the most of it and suddenly everything felt spontaneous. With fewer people, activities took half the time, which meant there was room for plenty more. Fancy a trip to the cinema? Sure! Another beer? Why not! Full English for breakfast? Absolutely. Bowling followed by pool, followed by ping pong and then the arcades? Plenty of time. What looked like a challenge turned into a wonderfully relaxed and brilliant little adventure.

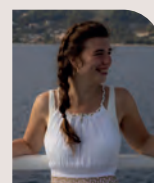


Verity Stockdale

My very first holiday as a carer took place shortly after the Covid pandemic.

Excitement was high as many people hadn't been able to explore much further than their sitting rooms for quite a while! But so too was anxiety, as routine testing and health concerns weighed heavily on people's minds. Towards the end of the holiday, a guest became ill and it was confirmed they had contracted Covid. The entire group was tested as a precaution, and myself and one other guest also had the dreaded "positive" double line. Fortunately, nobody was seriously poorly. So

with accommodation moved, board games sourced and activities rejigged, we made the most of the situation. The three of us had a wonderful time in our bubble. We went for some lovely walks, got to know each other really well, and I was so impressed by how well they handled such an unexpected turn of events. We will never forget our Covid hideaway days in France!



Amelia Weldon

A poem about the tricky journey I experienced coming home from a fantastic

week in Morocco last year.
*The flight home from Morocco had a big hiccup along the way,
 Though it's unusual and infrequent, so they say,
 Half the flights home were booked on a different day,
 Panicking everyone who had to stay,
 With help and encouragement, we uncovered another pathway,
 To enjoy and relax, forgetting our dismay,
 Swimming in a pool on the rooftop,
 Enjoying the sunset's colourful display,
 Getting home the next midday,
 I can safely say, we found our way.*

What's your best unexpected moment in travel? Email us at hello@beyondtravelmag.com



Mexico: beyond the fiesta

Florence Voller takes a closer look
at life abroad and the features
that make this unique country
accessible to everyone.

➤ **Mexico, full of people, salsa music, the smell of churros drifting through the air, scooters humming and firecrackers echoing down the street. Welcome to Puerto Vallarta, a small city on the West coast of Mexico. Full of life, beaches and happy hours.**

As we arrived, I could see my partner's spirits were low. Years of moving through the Americas had taught us that Mexico doesn't do background noise, it does immersion which for someone with autism, can be a challenge.

You arrive to a stew of sound, colour and smell: it is persistent and the effect can be overwhelming, but then that stereotype misses something essential...it's loud and bright but it's also patterned. And for many neurodivergent travellers, that means predictability which can be grounding. Keep an open mind and the city won't disappoint. Here are my tips for finding calm among the chaos and getting the most out of the city.

The Malecon,
Puerto Vallarta,
Mexico



The Malecón

The city's seaside boardwalk, a mix of street performers, vendors and tourists can make it busy by day but early in the morning it is calm, quiet and expansive. Birds skimming the water, locals exercising and old men sipping traditional Mexican coffee with a kick!

Planeta Vegetariano

Hungry? This family-run restaurant sits quietly behind the Malecon. It's a budget-friendly, all you can eat buffet, with natural light by day and soft lamps by night. Allowing you to enjoy the traditional dishes, soak up the atmosphere and then head outside to grab a sea view.

El Mirador de la Cruz

If you fancy a post-lunch hike, head to El Mirador (Hill of the Cross.) It's a short but steep climb with 312 steps where you will find a viewing tower with magnificent 360-degree views. Streets become lines, noise becomes distant and movement slows to a scroll.

Los Muertos Beach

It is known locally for being the 'party beach' but timing changes everything. Before 10am it is locals doing tai chi and dogs chasing waves. The sand's cool, the water's peaceful and you can sit for an hour and hear nothing but pelicans.

Zona Romantica

Getting its name from its cobblestone streets, traditional Mexican architecture, and scenic sunsets. The grid layout and consistent signage makes it blessedly predictable. The same stands are open morning and night, the weekend markets are quiet first thing and you can always find a quiet bench to relax and enjoy the atmosphere.

The Final Truth

This city won't dim its lights for you and it won't apologise for its joy. But it will offer patterns within the pandemonium. Arrive early, sit near water, bring earplugs and leave when you've had your fill and you will not be disappointed. It's as simple as that.**BT**



Lake Bled,
Slovenia

Where to next? Slovenia!

A land full of calm lakes, quaint villages, and mystical castles. Where the abundant forests turn a beautiful fiery crimson each year. Whose rich history has shaped its identity and landscape.



Slovenia, a small country nestled between Italy, Austria, Croatia and Hungary, is well known for its astounding scenery and vibrant cities. For the first time, excited to experience the wonders this country holds, Go Beyond is travelling to Slovenia.

Over half of Slovenia is covered with forests, making it one of the most forested countries in Europe. One can only imagine the spectacle when October comes around, and the lush green forests of Slovenia morph into a vibrant fiery palette of colours, becoming the global paradigm of autumn. What better time of year to visit!

Beyond the Lakes

Slovenia has over three hundred lakes in its small territory, making it a hotspot for wild

swimming and scenic views. The most famous lake, Lake Bled, features an island in its centre, which is topped with a church. The shore of the lake is also bordered with the historical village of Bled. Its impressive castle offers a magnificent view of the lake. This fairytale scene, blending natural beauty and heritage, will be one of the places Go Beyond will visit.

The Best Time to Visit

Most of these incredible lakes are surrounded by mountains, which can acquire a beautiful dusting of snow as early as October. These mountains are a key feature to Slovenia's terrain and geography. Whether one prefers to hike up or use a cable car, the view at the summit of these peaks is stunning and unique.

More Than Meets the Eye

Slovenia is more than just beautiful countryside. It's also a land full of good food, unique culture and vibrant towns. Slovenia is a country gaining international reputation for its perfect blend of wilderness and heritage, and becoming more and more popular as a travel destination.



To book this incredible holiday visit
gobeyondholidays.com



Slovenia All the details

Date

13th – 20th October 2026

Nights

7

Accommodation

Hotel Jezero

Food

All food will be catered for by the hotel

Price

£3710 (All Inclusive)

Activities

A guided tour of Ljubljana
Visit lake Bled
Enjoy a boat trip to Bohinj
Explore Predjama Castle
Take a cable car to Vogel

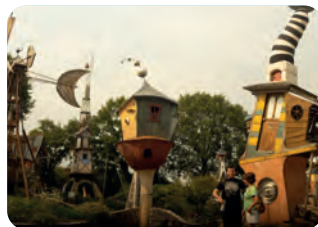
“Slovenia has over 300 lakes in its small territory”

Fancy your own adventure?

From breathtaking coastlines escapes to magical winter experiences, Go Beyond Holidays has an exciting line-up of supported holidays still to come in 2026!



Brittany Adventure
7th – 14th August



Culture of Brittany
15th – 22nd August



Brittany Gourmande
23rd – 30th August



Best of Brittany
31st Aug – 7th Sep



Malta
4th – 11th October



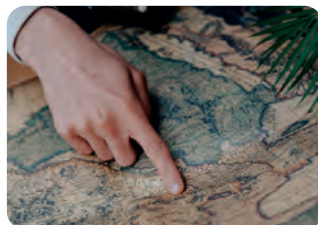
Autumn in Slovenia
13th – 20th October



Norway Northern Lights
22nd – 29th October



Christmas in Cornwall
9th – 14th December



**2027 adventures
coming soon!**

Whether you're looking for adventure, culture, relaxation or the chance to make new memories with new friends, there's a trip waiting for you.
gobeyondholidays.com



Go Beyond Holidays
...with you all the way!

